Princess Sophia Duleep Singh dressed in a white sari with a suffragette badge, a Dalhousie bird (named after a family whose members became prominent administrators in British India) is seen holding the Koh-i-noor diamond, "a symbol of sovereignty that was once the personal possession of Duleep Singh", the sisters reveal. "This represents the annexation of Duleep's kingdom by British Governor General Lord Dalhousie in 1849," they say, pointing out that as British Asians of mixed heritage, they relate to the displacement Maharaja Duleep Singh and his family experienced. The cotton sari denotes the family's connection to the story of cotton.

"And, as a key member of the suffragette movement, Sophia campaigned to promote workers' rights. That the cotton mills exploited child labour is symbolised by the figure of a little girl in rags who stands on novels by Charles Dickens," the sisters share. Their family also makes it into the exhibition in an accompanying animated film, titled *King Cotton: An Artist's Tale*, which explores the Indo-British history of cotton connected to Lancashire—the area the Singh family first migrated to from India, in 1948.

A lot has changed over the years and some might even feel racial prejudice is a thing of the past given the elevation of Rishi Sunak, a person of Indian origin, to the highest office in the UK. While The Singh Twins are, incidentally, thinking of documenting the landmark moment in British politics within a major artwork they've been commissioned to create for a new public South Asia Gallery, they prefer to temper their optimism with caution for now. "For his image to make it into our work, Mr Sunak will have to either prove his worth or else will have to do something so bad that we can't resist satirising it." They very much hope for it to be the former. ■

Anjana Vaswani

EXHIBITION

A SERVANT OF THE LINE

The Compulsive Act: Drawings by Jogen Chowdhury
Gallery Art Exposure, Kolkata
(Till December 17)

Most visual artists, especially painters, begin with the line. Sculptors can have a different route to arrive at their art, starting perhaps by tinkering first with malleable materials in childhood. But for painters, it usually begins with the first doodles on the page of a notebook or some other flat surface like a wall. The kid-scrawls trip over into legible lines, the lines take on a life of their own, demanding that the hand you gain control over the line and make it sing your individual song, the line also enslaves you, keeping you dancing to its tune.

Jogen Chowdhury is an artist whose lifelong *sadhana* has always maintained the line as its 'sa', as the foundational pole around which all his work unfurls. In this exhibition, we are treated to an immersion in the river of Jogen babu's unmistakable lines, from a few earlier works to quite a few more recent ones.



'Animal' (2016), (right) 'Aftermath' (2002)



produce more and more of them, that the sheer sensual pleasure of mark-making can be had repeatedly, that the satisfaction a 'finished' set of marks delivers becomes a regular reward around which, sometimes, a whole life can be built.

As youngsters become serious painters, many move on to finding their solace and solutions in tones or chromatic fields, while others stay married to the line, with everything else—tone and colour, form and the subject—being subservient to that line. Just as



Jogen Chowdhury is an artist whose lifelong work has always maintained the line as its foundation

Just as an author often takes time to find their 'voice', it takes repeated practice, conscious striving and, not least, life experience for a painter to find theirs. For Jogen babu, this moment comes at some point in the early 1970s when his hand starts to leave behind early influences and arrive at the vernacular of labyrinthine marks that will become instantly recognisable as a Chowdhury image. Of course, for a while, one can still see various small debts, to Jean Dubuffet, to Philip Guston, perhaps inadvertently even to *Playboy* cartoonist Gahan Wilson and to the inescapable octopus of Pablo Picasso. However, by the 1980s, we arrive at 'peak-Jogen', where he gives us those indelible figures that are at once mythical and contemporary, simultaneously grotesque, funny and *karuna*-invoking, men, women and other assorted creatures who could only be from Bengal or from India.

Doubtlessly, these drawings are the seeds from which the bigger works come, the heads against the dark backgrounds, the coupled figures twisted into sacks of cross-hatched pain, the fish, tigers and trees in dialogue with older forms of Patachitra and Madhubani, the politicians and the *seths*, and yet as works they are no less important to our experience and understanding of the disturbing and humorous universe that Jogen babu has given us. ■

Ruchir Joshi